inalienable rights because ‘[w]e believe that freedom is the undeniable birthright of all people, that every man has the inalienable right to enjoying the fruits of his labour and that every nation is indisputably the master of his resources’. For this reason, ‘[i]f any Govt. deprives them of those primary rights it is the right of people – nay it is their duty to destroy that Govt’.[1] With impeccable logic, they provided a moral justification for their actions, in that, ‘[s]ince the British govt. is a negation of these principles for which we stand it is our firm conviction that every effort made, every method adopted to bring about a Revolution and to destroy this Govt. is morally justified’. The revolutionaries were not idle talkers but believed in transforming their living conditions, which was why, ‘[w]e stand for a change, a radical change in the existing order of affairs in racial, political and economic spheres and the complete replacement of the existing order by a new era rendering the exploitation of man by man impossible and thus guaranteeing full liberty to all the people in all the spheres’. It was not just the elimination of racial and political injustice that they were after but that ‘[w]e feel that unless the whole social order is changed and socialistic society is established the whole world is in danger of a disastrous catastrophe’.

To the question of whether this meant that the young revolutionaries would resort to violence to achieve such far-reaching ends, they had a ready answer. It was as clear as it could be. If Gandhi disapproved of their errant ways that is because he failed to understand them. Nor did he make any attempt to do so. For him, it was enough that they deviated from his chosen path of ‘non-violence’. He had turned this into a fetish, wielding it uncompromisingly in all situations no matter the circumstances. For their temerity in taking a different course of action from him, he would refuse to align himself with these young men at all costs.

The letter of 5 May 1930 was written on the first day of the tribunal’s sitting and is crystal clear in its rejection of violence. Violence was not a central plank of revolutionary socialism. In a careful and sophisticated analysis, this letter explains that, ‘As regards the methods – peaceful or otherwise – to be adopted for the consummation of the revolutionary ideal,